# After the Bowling Stopped

## By Thadra Sheridan

### INTRODUCTION

*Just broken up with your boyfriend? Just gone on a date and wonder why he/she never calls you back? Do you feel sad and lonely and just sit there not knowing what to do? It's happened to the best of us. If there was only a way to fix this problem, so you don't have to feel this way. Well, there is! Write it down! Create art! Author a poem! That's what Thadra Sheridan did when nothing else seemed to work . . . "After the Bowling Stopped."*

Last night,
this guy played guitar on stage,
and it made me think of you, because
you play guitar on stage.
So I spent the next fifteen minutes
running a mental slide show.
LOS ANGLES:
You gave me half of your egg salad sandwich.
INDIANAPOLIS:
You grab me, because

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the smell of gasoline on my fingers
turns you on.
CHICAGO:
We play Ferris Bueller and
follow a kids' tour group
at the Institute of Arts.
ASHLAND:
You bowl five strikes in a row.
Etcetera, etcetera…
I find this still happens a lot.
Someone's wearing shoes, so
I think of you, because
*you* wear shoes.
You drink beverages.
YOU BREATHE AIR!
You can see how this might be a problem.
Sometimes I just
blurt your name out loud in my apartment
for no reason
like a Tourette's outburst,
and I'm supposed to write this
poem about you,

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because I keep saying I'm a poet.
And I've been trying
for the three years since you stopped
bowling in my presence, but it keeps coming out like,
*I hate you, I hate you*
*I wish I'd never agreed to*
*date you.*
or
*The day you left,*
*the sun set for the last time,*
*the trees wilted,*
*and happy little creatures ceased to scurry.*
or
*My heart*
*is a block of frozen, solid, petrified, cold, really hard ice*
*without you.*
or
*I don't need you.*
*Never did.*
*I CAN OPEN MY OWN PICKLE JARS!!!*

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Oh, I can write volumes
about every little
one-night-stand-pointless-encounter-waste-of-saliva
I've tried to replace you, but
*you?*
You're drying up the ink in
all my favorite pens.
You're hiding all my journals and
shorting out my keyboard.
You are the quintessential block.

You are the ultimate writer's block, if…
No, wait, that one works.
The point is,
I *know* you can eat a whole egg salad sandwich,
but I appreciate the gesture.
And that stretch of 90/94
from Chicago to Rockford has
never been the same
since I drove it home from the end of time.
And when you stayed over this past spring,
you slept on the couch,

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took a shower,
and left.
But it took me three days
to take your towel out of the bathroom
and five more to wash it.
I find I can't really write about something
until I have a little
distance perspective, but you're still
mashed up against me like a Siamese twin.
And the kicker is
I can't even say I want you back.
You were all shades of fiasco.
I was only on your mind if I was
waving my arms in front of you.

And you only gave me the sandwich because you were
BEING SUCH AN JERK
So if you asked,
would I take you back?
Yeah I totally would.
And that pisses me off.
But if I was with you right now, I'd be

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sitting in some hotel in New York,
getting my butt kicked at Scrabble, or
pitching a makeshift baseball game in
Gettysburg, Pennsylvania.
And my debt would be twice as ridiculous.
And I'd weigh a hundred pounds, because
you supplement eating and sleeping and
not in any good way.
But I wouldn't be here.
I wouldn't be
running my stupid life.
You are the rockstar me I'm
too impatient to wait for.
And you've got nothing to do with anything.
Most of my friends don't even know what you look like.
So you're all mine.
And a terrible kisser
and a really sore loser.
And I suspect you'll
litter my life with
unfinished pages about the
empty spaces you

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left in my apartment

for years to come.

And tonight,

when someone asks to borrow a guitar pick,

or uses the words,

and

or

the

I'll think of you;

snapshot something somewhere

away from here and today.

Not much I can really do about that, just

thought I'd mention it, because

it was on my mind.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Thadra Sheridan***
***Book: Rattle Poetry Magazine***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2009 National Qualifier***
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***https://www.rattle.com/product/i27/***

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